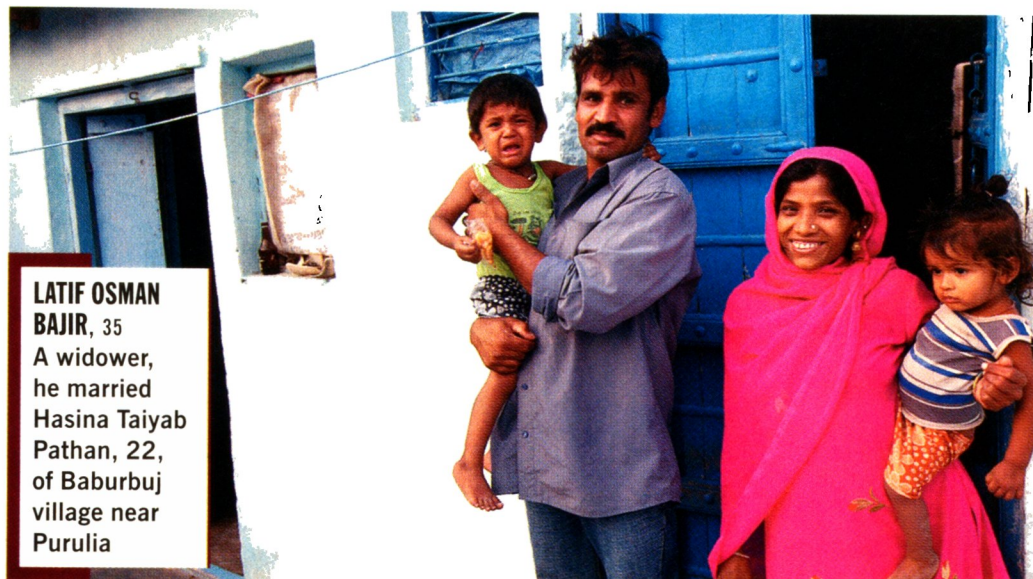




**LATIF OSMAN BAJIR, 35**  
A widower, he married Hasina Taiyab Pathan, 22, of Baburbuj village near Purulia

in extreme poverty they adjust well in poor Kutchi Muslim families which are relatively better off. Daily wage workers in Kutch earn Rs 70 to Rs 100 a day, which is double compared to West Bengal and Bihar. Says Meghiben Samalia, who works for a local NGO: "There is a big difference in the living standards of the two sets of people even though both fall in the poor category." The trend has been fuelled further because women from West Bengal are highly adjustable and have little personal demands compared to local girls. Marrying local girls is expensive while in the case of a Bengali or a Bihari bride, the only expenditure is on the travel of the bride's parents and a middleman, if any.



**TOLU KHAN, 22**  
The cattle owner from Banni area married Zakira Zahun Pathan, 19, hailing from Bankura, West Bengal

**E**ven widowers are now seeking brides. Bhadrashwar fisherman, Noormohammed Jakab Khungra, 42, brought 26-year-old Shamima Nazim Ansari, from Niyamadpur in Asansol. Says Khungra: "No one here was willing to give his daughter to me. Going to Bengal was the best option." Adds Shamima: "My mother had heard that Bengali girls married in Kutch were largely happy so she decided to try this option." Another widower with a Bengali bride is Latif Osman Bajir, 35, who married Hasina Taiyab Pathan, 22, from Purulia district three years ago. Hasina is the third of five daughters to be married in Kutch.

Docile and accommodating, the Bengali girls put in strenuous efforts to adjust themselves to their new envi-

ronment. Fortunately, most Kutchi families are liberal. In the initial months, the brides are not expected to do household chores. Says Rabrakhiya Khudana, Tolu's uncle: "We understand that the girls need to adjust." Zakira, used to a diet of rice, dal and fish, finds that Kutchi Muslims in the Banni area eat fish and rice occasionally. She, therefore, learnt to cook local dishes. She adds: "When people are good it is not difficult to adjust." What also helps is the large number of Bengali women in the area. Some villages have as many as 10 Bengali girls. Says Karimkhan Jat: "One of the things we do is to introduce a new bride to a fellow Bengali in the village or in a neighbouring village. That works as a tonic as they are initially nervous."

Interestingly, the grooming for the brides starts as soon as one lands. Her husband takes her out for tea to his relative's place. Says Hasina, wife of Latif Osman Bajir: "That's their first exposure to Kutchi culture and local lifestyle. For me, the tea visits were educative and reassuring." In most cases, it is the husband's female relatives who become the brides' friends and play a big role in grooming them. Admits Saira: "When I got married my husband's cousin, Amina, became my anchor. She taught me the language as well as preparing Kutchi dishes."

Even though dictated by necessity, the new marriage alliances between Muslims from Gujarat and faraway West Bengal prove that there is indeed unity in diversity. ■